The Almost Moon

By Anne Sebold

HELEN: When all is said and done, killing my mother came easily. Dementia, as it descends, has a way of revealing the core of the person affected by it. My mother's core was rotten like the brackish water at the bottom of a weeks-old vase of flowers. She had been beautiful when my father met her and still capable of love when I became their late-in-life child, but by the time she gazed up at me that day, none of this mattered.

INTRODUCTION

Helen Knightly, a middle-aged Philadelphia divorcee, has sacrificed her marriage and family to care for her vicious, mentally unbalanced mother, Clair. Sebold explores the complex ties between mothers and daughters, the meaning of devotion, and the often too-thin line between love and hate.

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HELEN: It was a cool October morning. When I arrived, my mother was sitting upright in her wing chair, wrapped in a mohair shawl, and mumbling to herself. *(to Clair)* Mother.

CLAIR: *(looking up and smiling)* Bitch.

HELEN: The thing about dementia is that sometimes you feel like the afflicted person has a trip wire to the truth, as if they can see beneath the skin you hide in. (to Clair) Mother, it's Helen.

CLAIR: *(rudely)* I know who you are!

HELEN: My mother looked at me. It was a horrible bottomless look. She pouted first, her lower lip jutting out and then quivering. She was going to cry. I left the room and walked to the kitchen. Whenever I came, I found good reason to spend many of the hours I was supposed to be with my mother in every room of the house but the one in which she sat. I heard the low moan begin that I'd been hearing all my life. It was a moan the notes of which were orchestrated to elicit pity. My father had always been the one to run to her. After his death, it fell to me. For more than twenty years, with greater or lesser diligence, I had been

attending to her, rushing over when she called saying her heart would burst, or taking her on increasing rounds of doctors' visits as she aged.

Late in the afternoon of that day, I was in the screened-in back porch, sweeping out the straw mat. I had left the door open a crack so that I could hear her. Then into the cloud of dust that surrounded me came an unmistakable odor. My mother had needed to go to the bathroom but couldn't get up.
I dropped the broom and ran to my mother. She had not, as I may have momentarily hoped, died and suffered the resultant loosening of bowels. Instead, she sat in her chair, having soiled herself.

CLAIR: Number two!

HELEN: The smell had filled the room within seconds. I walked back to the porch twice to take in huge drafts of dusty air and could think of nothing else but presenting my mother in the way she would have wanted to be seen. I knew I was going to have to call the ambulance. I knew, as I had for some time, that my mother was heading out of this life.

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(to Clair) Mom, I'm going to help you clean up, and then we're going to make some calls. *(to audience)* Certain as I said it that she did not recognize the name or the daughter who said it.

I knelt down in front of her and looked up into her face. I hated her more than I'd ever hated anyone. Still, I reached up, as if I were finally allowed to touch a precious thing, and ran my fingers down her long silver braid. *(whispering)* Mom. *(to audience)* I said it because I knew it would be still in the air. No reverberations, no response.

But the wetness was making her unhappy. Like a snail trapped in sunlight, say — anxious to get away from an element that caused pain. I went from kneeling to half bending over. I placed my shoulders against her shoulders, careful not to put any weight on her. I leaned in like a football player on a tackle and then lifted up. She was both lighter and heavier than I'd expected.

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I got her to standing with ease, but once she was upright, she collapsed in my arms. It was all I could do not to drop her, bringing both of us to the ground. As I adapted to the balance of holding her full weight, I could not help but think of my father, how year after year he carried the burden of her, apologized to the neighbors, dried her copious tears, and how this body had folded into his over and over again like so much batter until the two of them became one.

I felt like weeping myself then. I dragged my mother, with her trying, I could feel, to help, over to the staircase leading up to her bath. I questioned my sanity. How, I wondered, did I think this feat was possible? I panted on the carpeted steps but did not give up. I was determined to clean my mother and to dress her in fresh clothes before I called the ambulance.

My mother began to snore. Her head tilted back over my shoulder so that I could see her ancient, mottled face and neck. I looked at her cheekbones, as sharp as they had always been — almost painful now in her

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cadaverous flesh. Who will love me? I thought, and then banished this question by looking out at the birch leaves in the fading sunlight.

I twisted out from under her, and she moaned like a collapsing bag of air. I sat by her body on the stairs. I had to get out of there, and I thought, suddenly, of the bathtub among the rocking horses in the shed. I left my mother dozing and turned and ran up the stairs, darting into her cluttered bedroom for blankets, and the pink powder room for towels. I noticed the hush in the upstairs hallway and looked at the pictures on the walls, pictures that would soon be gone. I imagined the dark squares they would leave behind them where no sun had reached for years, and the echoes that would resound from the curtain-less storm windows and the thick plaster-and-brick walls. I began to sing. I sang nonsense.

Cat-food commercials and childhood songs, the latter a habit that had been handed down from my mother, a way to stave off the onset of nerves. The need for noise overwhelmed me, but as I headed down the

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stairs, I grew quiet again. I saw that my mother had slumped down and lay on the floor, her body on the old wine-red Persian rug.

(to Claire) No, Mother, no. *(to audience)* Realizing that it was more useless than talking to a dog. A dog cocked her head. A dog gave you a soulful look. Why like this? I stood over her body with my arms full of blankets and towels, and I began to weep. I placed the towels on the bottom stair and took my grandfather's red-and-black Hudson Bay blanket, spreading it out on the floor beside her. Then, so the wool would not scratch, I put a white Mexican wedding blanket down on top of that.

I bent down and put my arms up under my mother's armpits. Her eyes snapped open.

CLAIR: What on earth are you doing?

HELEN: I blinked. I kept my arms tense. Would she ever be powerless?

CLAIR: *(Screaming)* Daniel! Daniel!

HELEN: Dad's not here, Mom. *(to audience)* She looked up at me, her face dimmed and then reignited again, like

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a match flaring in the dark. To be that close to her. To be holding on to her and to see her brain open up like that, its scrambled insides, it was all I could do to keep to my task. I placed her body in the blankets and made an open-ended package with her talking head sticking out. Then I rested the towels on top of her chest and breathed slowly, counting to ten before I spoke. *(to Clair)* We are going on a sleigh ride. *(to audience)* And in my fists, I balled up the two free ends of the blanket, partially lifting her body off the floor. I heaved her over the carpet of the dining room, in through the kitchen, and out the side door.

CLAIR: Toot! Toot! . . . Toot! Toot!

HELEN: And then she grew silent and stared at the outside like a child in front of flickering Christmas lights. I wanted to ask her: When was the last time you went into your backyard? When was the last time you smelled a flower or trimmed a shrub or just sat in the rusted white iron lawn chair?

Grief was coming heavily now. Something about being outside, being in the fresh air, away from the acrid

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scent of her and the mothball smell of the closed-up house. My mother lay in her blanketed cocoon on the small, raised side porch, which thankfully was at least partially shielded from the next-door neighbors by vine-covered latticework.

I touched her treasured braid again. Some years ago her hair had passed out of its wiry stage and become soft. It had always been her crowning glory..

Outside, with the air rushing over her, the fecal scent dissipated, and I could think realistically again. I would not make it to the shed. What had I thought? The damage of dragging her down the three steps, of trying to heave her off the porch. And what would I fill the ancient bathtub with? Cold water from the backyard hose? What had I been thinking?

(to Clair) This is it, Mom. This is as far as we go. *(to audience)* She did not smile or say "bitch" or wail some final lament. I like to think that by that time she was busy taking in the scent of her garden, feeling the late-afternoon sun on her face, and that somehow in

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the moments that had elapsed since she'd last spoken, she'd forgotten she'd ever had a child and that, for so many years now, she'd had to pretend she loved it.

I wish I could say that she made it easy on me. That she pointedly listed all the sins she had committed during her long life. She was eighty-eight. The lines on her face were now the cross-hatchings of fine old porcelain. Her eyes were closed. Her breathing ragged.

There is no excuse to give, I know, so here is what I did: I took the towels with which I had meant to bathe her, and not thinking that near the latticework or by the back fence there might stand a witness, I smashed these downy towels into my mother's face. Once begun, I did not stop.

She struggled, her blue-veined hands, with the rings she feared would be stolen if she ever took them off, grabbed at my arms. I pushed down harder. The towels shifted, and I saw her eyes. I held the towels

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for a long time, staring right at her, until I felt the tip of her nose snap and saw the muscles of her body go suddenly slack and knew that she had died.

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